

Inductive-Plot Sermon Template

Text & Context:

- **Passage:**
- **One-Sentence Synopsis:**
- **Setting in the Larger Biblical Storyline:** (e.g., Already/Not-Yet, covenant moment, exile & return, kingdom anticipation, etc.)

Big Idea / Gospel Claim:

(The single sentence your listeners should be able to repeat at lunch.)

Key Theological Lenses:

- **Christological:** (How does this passage point to/reveal Jesus?)
- **Pneumatological:** (Where is the Holy Spirit's work or presence in this?)
- **Eschatological:** (How does this play out in the redemptive metanarrative of Genesis 3:15)

I. Thematic & Evocative Introduction

(Homiletical Plot 1: "Oops" - Upsetting the Equilibrium)

- **Conceptual Hook:**
 - Start wide: a cultural moment, historical anecdote, current event, or pop-culture metaphor that raises a universal question or shared human experience.
 - *Goal: Pique curiosity and establish relevance.*
- **Establish the "Normal" (Equilibrium):**
 - Describe the seemingly settled, ordinary, or expected situation—both in the world/culture and as it might appear on the surface of the biblical text.
 - *Goal: Create a baseline that will soon be challenged.*
- **Disrupt the Normal (Upsetting the Equilibrium):**
 - Introduce the tension, the problem, the "uh-oh" moment. Expose the crack in the wall—injustice, fear, doubt, suffering, an unanswered prayer, a contradiction.
 - This is where the tension begins to surface.
 - *Goal: Create a felt need, a sense that something is amiss.*
- **Curiosity/Empathy Sparks:**
 - Pose a direct, relatable question or tell a story that invites the

congregation to lean in and connect personally.

- e.g., *"Have you ever felt like...?", "What happens when...?", "Let's go back there. We're standing there, looking at..."*
- *Goal: Bridge the abstract to the personal, fostering engagement.*

II. Immersion & Analysis

(Homiletical Plot §2: "Ugh" - Analyzing the Discrepancy + Narrative Deep-Dive)

- **Multi-Angle Scene-Setting (Textual Exploration):**

- Dive into the biblical passage. Provide contextual details (where are we? How did we get here? What is happening? What does it mean?).
- Try to create empathy for the characters within the text
- Offer historical, cultural, or linguistic nuggets that illuminate the passage.
- *Goal: Make the biblical world come alive and reveal its complexities.*

- **Name the Deeper Issue (The Real Discrepancy):**

- Go beyond the surface problem. What's *really* going on here? What core human dilemma, unseen realm battle, or theological question is being exposed?
- This is where you analyze *why* the equilibrium was upset.
- *Goal: Identify the root of the tension. What is the big picture in the eternal battle?*

- **Audience Mirror (Connecting Then to Now):**

- Explicitly frame how this same tension, discrepancy, or deep issue manifests today.
- e.g., *"When we think about it? Are we that different?"*
- *Goal: Show the timeless relevance of the text and the shared nature of the struggle.*

III. The Turn — Disclosing the Clue

(Homiletical Plot §3: "Aha" - Disclosing the Clue to Resolution)

- **A-ha! / Gospel Reveal (The Pivot):**

- This is the crucial turning point. Where does the text itself, or the broader biblical narrative, offer a surprising shift, a glimmer of hope, a divine intervention, or a new perspective that begins to address the tension?
- Show, don't just tell, this turn. Let the narrative itself reveal it.
- *Goal: Introduce the solution/resolution, often unexpectedly.*

- **Christ at the Center (The Ultimate Clue):**

- How does Jesus (His life, death, resurrection, teachings, identity) reframe everything related to this tension?
- Explore typology that may be in the text.
- *Goal: Set up for a Christocentric resolution.*
- **Eschatological Pulse (Spirit's Present Activity):**
 - Draw the line from the "Already" of Christ's work to the "Not-Yet" being realized through the Holy Spirit's present activity.
 - How does this narrative fit into the ongoing spiritual war?
 - *Goal: Emphasize the ongoing, active work of God in the world and in the believer.*

IV. Experiencing the Gospel

(Homiletical Plot §4: "Yea" - Experiencing the Gospel)

- **Embodied Illustration or Testimony:**
 - Share a compelling story (personal, historical, contemporary), or a powerful metaphor that allows listeners to *feel* or *taste* the grace and truth of the Gospel reveal.
 - This is just an explanation. It's living it.
 - *Goal: Move from intellectual understanding to heart-level resonance.*
- **Emotional & Spiritual Pause:**
 - Intentionally slow the pace. Create space for reflection.
 - Invite holy wonder, lament (if appropriate to the prior tension), relief, gratitude, awe—whatever emotional and spiritual response aligns with the text's resolution.
 - Music can be powerful here.
 - *Goal: Allow the weight and beauty of the Gospel moment to sink in.*
- **Connection to the Hurting / Wandering / Hopeful:**
 - Speak directly and pastorally to different categories of people likely present.
 - *Goal: Make the application personal, relatable and specific.*

V. Anticipating the Consequences (Living It Out)

(Homiletical Plot §5: "Wee" - Anticipating the Results of the Gospel — grace-rooted response)

- **Invitation, Not Obligation:**
 - Frame the response as a natural outflow of the grace received, not a

burdensome duty.

- *Goal: Motivate by grace, not guilt. This isn't punishment, it's an opportunity.*

- **Practical Trajectories (Multi-Dimensional Response):**

- Suggest concrete, yet broad, pathways for living out this Gospel truth.
- *Goal: Provide actionable, but not overly prescriptive, direction.*

- **Spirit-Empowered Next Steps:**

- Emphasize reliance on the Holy Spirit for transformation and action.
- Offer compelling altar call for response to the message as well as for various needs

Goal: Reinforce dependence on God for any lasting change.